Q+A

A Dance Awakening

Dr Sonal Mansingh on curating the ongoing *Festival of New Choreographies – KalaYatra 2026* (Jan. 13-29) in Delhi, which brings together 10 eminent dance institutions and gurus from across India

Q. How did you envision this festival and what is its main aim?

For many decades, I've been presenting different festivals and programmes, but most are based on a particular theme or issue. I thought of doing a festival of choreographies because people have to continuously be introduced to artists who are doing some meaningful work. There was no point presenting the same old choreographies.... It becomes comfortable to repeat them and I have never liked to be comfortable.

Q. Can you tell us a bit about the curation and why you chose particular choreographies?

I wanted thinking artists. Secondly, I was looking for those who have not performed in Delhi for many years. And thirdly, after speaking to them, the assurance that they will come on board to present something new, created especially for this festival.

Q. During your tenure as a Rajya Sabha MP, you highlighted the needs of performing artists. What do you think is the need of the hour now?

There are events and festivals happening by the dozen and the government is really pouring in money for such big events. On the other side, there is a crying need to create more hubs for cultural activities. Unfortunately, dance suffers the most. Also, it is a very delicate situation for dancers because their career span is short.

Q. You have been dancing for over six decades, yet you think of yourself as a work in progress. What do you wish to achieve now and what is your hope for yourself and the performing arts?

What I wish for myself is for my hair and teeth to remain intact (laughs). Secondly, to keep on contributing new ideas and energising the scene... and see some better days for art and the artists.

—with ***Deepali Dhingra***



Photograph by CHANDRADEEP KUMAR